

ED ON THE HUNT

The Enforcement Directorate is investigating 10 leaders of the ruling MVA alliance

AJIT PAWAR, Finance minister (NCP)

CHARGE: Bought Jarandeshwar Co-op Sugar Mill for Rs 65.75 lakh, lower than the market price in 2010. Pawar says, "Let ED investigate, I was cleared of all charges"

NAWAB MALIK, Minorities welfare minister (NCP)

CHARGE: Bought a three-acre plot in Mumbai for Rs 75 lakh, lower than its actual price, from an aide of Haseena Parkar, sister of gangster Dawood Ibrahim

ANIL DESHMUKH, Ex-home minister (NCP)

CHARGE: Allegedly sent Rs 4.7 crore in extortion money to family-controlled trust, Sai Shikshan Sanstha

ANIL PARAB, Transport minister (SS)

CHARGE: Illegally constructed a palatial resort on farmland in hometown Ratnagiri

PRAJAKT TANPURE, MoS, Urban development (NCP)

CHARGE: Purchased Ram Ganesh Gadkari Cooperative Sugar factory in Nagpur at a price much lower than the actual

HASSAN MUSHRIF, Rural development minister (NCP)

CHARGE: Allegedly involved in a Rs 100 crore corruption case involving the Appasaheb Nalawade sugar factory, Kolhapur. Mushrif says he is only "helping the factory as the local legislator"

SANJAY RAUT, Party spokesperson (SS)

CHARGE: Allegedly got an interest-free loan of Rs 50 lakh for wife Varsha from Pravin Raut, an accused in the PMC Bank scam

BHAVNA GAWLI, MP (SS)

CHARGE: Converted a trust with assets of Rs 69 crore into an NGO under her control in Washim, her constituency. She says, "I myself am a complainant in the case"

ANAND ADSUL, Ex-MP (SS)

CHARGE: Allegedly involved in a fraud of Rs 980 crore in City Cooperative Bank, Amravati

PRATAP SARNAIK, MLA (SS)

CHARGE: Allegedly involved in a scam involving the National Spot Exchange Ltd

Patel which Dawood used to foment terror activities in India between 2005 and 2012. But on March 3, the agency amended its stand, saying there was a typographical error in the chargesheet—the amount paid to Patel was Rs 5 lakh. The ED's claim that Malik has links to Dawood has left the MVA furious. NCP chief Sharad Pawar also launched a broadside against the BJP-led Union government, saying the ED was being misused for political gains. "If a person is Muslim, it is very convenient to link him to Dawood," Pawar said, defending Malik.

The ED's action is a follow-up of an FIR filed by another central agency, the National Investigation Agency (NIA), this January against Dawood and his close aides under the stringent Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA). The ED has searched 10 premises in Mumbai connected with Iqbal Kaskar (Dawood's brother) and Salim 'Fruit' Qureshi (brother-in-law of Chhota Shakeel, Dawood's right-hand man). The agency has also registered a money-laundering case against the late Haseena Parkar, Dawood and his accomplices like Iqbal Mirchi, Chhota Shakeel and Javed Chikna. It says it has evidence of several alleged hawala transactions linked to ill-gotten money from extortion, drug trafficking and sale of real estate in the Nagpada and Bhendi Bazar areas of Mumbai.

Sensing the political repercussions of the allegations against Malik, the MVA is also out for blood. And their target is Fadnavis. The appointment of Sanjay Pandey is a prelude to this, say sources. Pandey has a clean track record so no one can point fingers but, more importantly, he was at the helm of an inquiry against three senior officers—Rashmi Shukla, Param Bir Singh and ADGP Deven Bharti—all favoured officers of Fadnavis. In his capacity as interim DGP, Pandey had also recommended that the state suspend Param Bir Singh for violating service rules after he did not report to work for 289 days without intimation. Two years ago, Pandey had submitted a report to the state government, holding Deven Bharti responsible for aiding Dawood's activities in Mumbai.

Chief Minister Uddhav Thackeray has alleged that the Union government is trying to browbeat the states. "Don't the central agencies have any work to do, outside of Maharashtra and West Bengal?" he asked sarcastically at a function organised by a Marathi newspaper on February 26. Fadnavis, meanwhile, is waiting for his moment. He presented several video tapes in the Legislative Assembly on March 8 alleging that the MVA had conspired to trap him and other BJP leaders in false cases. More fireworks are expected soon. ■